



ROUGH CUT | KAVEREE BAMZAI

Making Samosa Movies



Movie mogul Joseph E. Levine once said, "You can fool all the people all the time if the advertising is right and the budget is big enough". Guess what? In the past two years in India, big money spent on small ideas has usually boomeranged badly. India's first kung fu film? Yes, that was a dud called *Chandni Chowk to China*. Bollywood's first special effects laden children's fantasy? Hmm. *Drona*? *Aladin*? And India's first romcom? Yes, it was an awful farce called *Kambakht Ishq*. Why is it that Bollywood needs to clone Hollywood, an industry that doesn't corner more than 4 per cent of the box office revenue in India? Well, three reasons. One, the moneybags are old and the "talent" is shiny. The writers and directors who sell the ideas usually watch their movies either by downloading or renting them, very rarely do they go to run down halls with the stuffing coming out of the seats, which is why they don't know what people want. The producers, who usually have been around for longer, do but are so dazzled by the presentation skills of the smart young pups that they forget to count the money before handing it out. Movies that are possible in less are made in more, over a longer period of time and sold at much higher prices. Two, the stars who greenlight "projects" tend to read less and listen more. *Hitch* in Hindi? Call it *Partner*, hope it doesn't sink under the weight of the supersize star egos, and pray it has potential for a sequel. Three, there's no effort to adapt even if the stories are not original. No one ever thought *Sholay* was a mint fresh original. But it was adapted smartly by Salim-Javed into the ultimate desi Western.

So why has Bollywood stopped making samosa thrillers and jalebi romances? Why is it obsessed with popcorn capers and maple syrup mush? Clearly, the audience still loves blood-pumping body contact over high-tech wirework if the success of the

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thump-and-grind *Wanted* is anything to go by. Clearly, also moviegoers still like the elaborate love stories crossing continents and involving lots of Punjabi if the delighted acceptance of *Love Aaj Kal* is an indicator. Yet, *Aladin* was to be made at a cost of Rs 15 crore before the director got ambitious and wanted to make a summer franchise at Rs 60 crore. *Blue* was just an idea from a neophyte director before it caught the fancy of a big bucks star whose presence made the producers dizzy enough to commit Rs 80 crore. It's not to say that Bollywood has to churn out only desi movies to engage with mass audiences. *Rock On!!* and *Wake Up Sid* speak in voices that smaller segments relate to, but authentically. If there's anything that this year has taught Bollywood's biggies apart from humility is that cheesiness works, but it has to be made from paneer.

WHY DOESN'T BOLLYWOOD STICK TO ITS CORE STRENGTH INSTEAD OF CHASING IMPORTS? AREN'T JALEBIS BETTER THAN MAPLE SYRUP?

SIGNPOSTS

APPOINTED: P. S.

Veeraraghavan as the chief of Vikram Sarabhai Space Centre. He was director, ISRO Inertial Systems, till now and succeeds K. Radhakrishnan.

WON: Former Under-10 chess world champion **Sahaj Grover**, the International Open Chess Tournament in



Le Touquet, France. The win makes him the youngest Indian international master.

APPOINTED: **Rajeet Mittal** as the high commissioner to Bangladesh. A 1977 ips officer, he succeeds Pinak R. Chakravarty.

OPENED: The **Central Jail** in Arunachal Pradesh, the state's first-ever prison. Till now, undertrials and convicts were lodged in police station lockups in the state.

WON: By **Nitin Jain**, 18, the gold medal at the International Olympiad on Astrology and Astrophysics at Tehran, Iran. He is also this year's Indian Institute of Technology topper.